



theWindow

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Being a Mission-Driven Church

BY PRESTON GRAHAM



from the Pastor

This year you will hear a lot about a "mission-driven church." To set your minds at ease, we don't mean by this a millennium-driven church, as if the turn of the millennium had any spiritual significance for us whatsoever. Rather, as a church community we need always to think seriously about what it means to be a church that responds to Christ's call to "make disciples of all the nations" (Mt. 28:19). In Christ's context, the word "nations" (ethnos) referred to the Gentiles and would have encompassed all people outside the nation of Israel—that is, all people groups that had not been reached by the gospel through redemptive history. A mission-driven church, then, is simply a church that takes seriously the call of Christ to take the gospel to these "unreached" peoples. Our discussions this year will take place during a "convocation on worship" after church for the month of October, in our planned School of Dis-

covery course on church evangelism this fall, and at our annual missions banquet in January. But I hope it will also be an informal, non-programmed topic of discussion and prayer throughout our church as well. To get the discussion started, here are some initial thoughts to ponder.

In the early days of our church (only about seven years ago), "mission" was also about survival. Our mission was more or less to plant a PCA church in greater New Haven. In order to do this, we targeted (even if unconsciously) that ethnos, or group of people closest to our own "group" or demographic description. We did this because we had to start somewhere, and why not begin with the vernacular that we already, more or less, shared? Yet too often, this early strategic move in order to plant a church in a given region can be confused with a principled, long-range plan—as if merely having a PCA church in New Haven were the same as reaching the "nations" of New Haven with the Reformed faith and the glory of Christ.

As a church becomes established, its driving momentum can undergo a subtle change from a survival mentality to a sustaining mentality.

This change corresponds spiritually with a transition from a mission-driven church to a maintenance-driven church. In fact, one of the more common rules of thumb circulating around our denomination predicts that the typical church will make this transition in as little as seven years. At the core of this transition, the church's focus changes from building a church that will take the gospel to people it has not yet reached to maintaining a church that will meet the needs of its members and their families. In short, the transition is to a church driven by personal needs instead of one driven by the ambition to see Christ exalted by every ethnos. Perhaps this is justified by confusing what is comfortable for my own style or vernacular with orthodoxy or by equating what meets my needs with the good news of the gospel. Yet at the heart of missions is the desire for more and more people from more and more different communities to be brought to their knees professing that Jesus Christ is Lord! (see 'Pastor' on page 3)

Report on the Session Retreat

BY ALAN PHILLIPS



Briefing

Each summer the elders of CPC take a leadership retreat. The focus of the retreat is on planning for the coming year, but we also devote time to spiritual growth and renewal and prayer. This year we went to Emerald Lake in New York's Catskill Mountains. We were privileged to use the vacation home of Dexter Chen's parents, which provided a comfortable, quiet, and picturesque setting for the retreat.

In preparation for the retreat, we all read the book *Blame It on the Brain* by Edward T. Welch. In our society today, there is a growing tendency to attribute misbehavior to the brain. The author uses Scripture to help differentiate

genuine brain disorders from problems rooted in our sinful nature. The author's discussion of the interaction between the brain and the soul was particularly thought-provoking and helped generate some excellent discussion.

Our church looks less like a church plant and more like an established church, and yet we need to maintain a focus and purpose of outreach and evangelism.

For spiritual refreshment, Preston led a series of devotions from the Psalms, which were interspersed throughout the three days to provide a break from our planning work.

As we launched into our planning, we were (see 'Retreat' on page 2)

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Terrific Thursdays

Eating pizza on the beach, exploring Indian caves, boating through Captain Kidd's stomping grounds, screaming and splashing down enclosed water slides are just a few of the fun memories from Terrific Thursdays this summer. Parents, children, neighbors, and friends all gathered together each week for a day of fantastic fun and fellowship. During our grand finale, it was especially nice to watch the older kids interacting with the little ones as our younger moms were given a "Mother's Morning Out."

This year was our seventh summer of Terrific Thursdays and our families loved them! Fellowship among our church families as well as an outreach to neighbors and friends are a couple of the benefits experienced each summer. Please join us for our eighth summer next year and DON'T FORGET to keep your Thursdays free and open as you plan for summer 2000.



Mothers and children enjoy lunch on a recent Terrific Thursday.

Retreat (continued from page 1)

challenged by the fact that our church is now more than five years old. It looks less like a church plant and more like an established church, and yet we need to maintain a focus

Is it possible to be theologically driven in worship yet stylistically sensitive and culturally relevant?

and purpose of outreach and evangelism. We must take the Gospel to the nations. We wrestled with the tendency that some older churches have of falling into a maintenance

mode, taking care of their own, but losing the zeal for reaching out to others as we have been commanded to do by our Savior. Our church has not fallen into maintenance mode, yet we want to set in motion the appropriate plans and directions to ensure that we don't!

As such, we all agreed that in the coming year we should emphasize evangelism in much of what we do. In discussing how we should go about doing that, we discussed three theological issues which bear upon our specific goals and strategies: ecumenical involvement with other churches and Christian organizations, the spirituality of the Church, and being theologically driven while maintaining a sensitivity to

the cultural vernacular of our surrounding city. Our discussion centered on such questions as: How might we reach more people in New Haven with the Gospel? Is our current worship

It is our prayer as a session that every member of the church will personally embrace the vision of reaching the nations with the Gospel

service "style" relevant to all of the people groups in New Haven? Is it possible to be theologically driven in worship yet stylistically sensitive and culturally relevant? Through what means beyond our worship service might we reach more people in New Haven with the Gospel? How might we best utilize our financial and human resources in fulfilling our mission?

As you can imagine, many very exciting plans and new directions have been planned for the upcoming year and beyond as we seek to establish ourselves as a mission-driven church. We will be presenting these ideas and approaches at our annual congregational meeting and banquet on Sunday, September 5th. It is our prayer as a session that every member of the church will personally embrace the vision of reaching the nations with the Gospel, and that this year will be both challenging and spiritually rewarding as we stretch ourselves and strive to fulfill the Great Commission together in New Haven and the surrounding area.



Tom, George, Preston, Cliff and Alan (from left to right) on their recent Elders' retreat.

Check out Your Library!

BY PRESTON GRAHAM

Here's an idea! Why not get yourself a hot cup of coffee or tea (hot chocolate for those of you with a sweet tooth), and spend an hour or two at your CPC study center library? There is an amazing number of books, journals, magazines, videos, and audio tapes that would surely make for a refreshing break from your hectic life.

Perhaps you have missed the Church History lectures given by Jon and Jonathan. You could listen to one of their tapes on Luther or the Reformation while browsing through back issues of Christian History magazine on the same topic. Or perhaps you want to sit in the reading room with an article from Table Talk

on a topic that interests you. Or you could select a good book on building a happy marriage, prayer, raising a teenager, the work and person of Christ, or knowing God's will in your life. In short, we have been blessed with many great books from many different eras on just about every conceivable topic. There are books with great sermons in them and books from many of the most notable Christian pastors and theologians of both yesterday and today. We have many of George MacDonald's great novels. We have George Baxter's Christian Director that offers pastoral advice on everything from parenting to finding a spouse. We have most of R.C. Sproul's books and the Complete Works by Francis Schaeffer and his wife Edith. You could begin one of the great fiction works by C. S. Lewis, or maybe one of his essays on suffering or apologetics. For you his-

tory types we have the great Philip Schaff series, The History of the Christian Church. If you are interested in theology, try of course Calvin's Institutes (you will be surprised at how readable he is) or one of the many contemporary authors on theological subjects. All of these things and much more are calling you to the church study center for a coffee break or maybe a planned day of study. It is a resource that has grown quite significantly even in the last six months. Our pastoral and teaching teams have been busy locating just those books that might really make a difference in your life.

A special thanks to Jon Hinkson, who has found bargains from around the world to make our library a place all the more perfect for a hot cup of coffee or tea!

Pastor (continued from page 1)

Some will do this eventually under the wrath of God, and others will do this under the grace of God—but the effect will be that people from every nation will see Jesus for what he really is. Given our church's now seven-year history, and human nature being what it is, we need to pray fervently that our church will be mission-driven. As you do this, consider the following brief description of what a mission-driven church is and is not.

— A mission-driven church is serious about reaching the “nations” but is not serious about necessarily being popular. While we should expect a mission-driven church to be multi-national, we would not necessarily expect it to be popular. Christ and the apostles were absolutely clear on this point—the “last days” will be characterized by a people who walk a narrow road to heaven, but those people will be from many nations. A mission-driven church is not a “church-growth” church if we mean by that a church that is popular because it is democratic.

— A mission-driven church is serious about theological orthodoxy as distinguished from cultural orthodoxy. A church driven to reach the nations will necessarily distinguish between a theology of “no distinctions” and a theology that maintains human distinctions. Paul's point in Romans was that one of the tests of true orthodoxy is that it can be understood and embraced by every nation. Styles may change, mediums of communication may change, and even these things will be measured by the degree to which they live out true orthodoxy within a given culture, but the true gospel knows “no distinctions.” To be a mission-

driven church, then, is to be a theologically-driven church, albeit one that distinguishes theology from sociology. Confessionalism and mission go hand in hand! And a true confession can in fact be measured at least partially by its capacity to transcend all human distinctions.

— A mission-driven church is serious about a full gospel—and by “full gospel” we don't mean the movement that emphasizes a health-wealth, feelings-based experience of an individualized Holy Spirit, but the gospel that seeks to plant the mediated presence of Christ as prophet, priest, and king into every nation. This means that a mission-driven church is not merely interested in getting out a message (the prophetic aspects) but also in establishing a social organization of shepherding (kingly aspects) and doxological worship in the sacramental presence of Christ as mediator between God and humanity (priestly aspects). Through the full gospel, we avoid the too-frequent dichotomies between a “social gospel” and a “propositional gospel” or “deed vs. word” way of thinking. Instead we see a gospel focused on the mediated presence of Christ whereby He saves his people through word, deed and sacraments.

— A mission-driven church is serious about wanting every person to participate in the gospel. This does not mean that every person is responsible for every aspect of the gospel ministry, but rather that every person should be involved in some aspect of the gospel ministry. In short, the gospel mission is given to the church, which should have both formal and informal venues that collaborate with each other to spread the gospel. Each individual is

called to participate in the gospel work of the church, but no person should think so highly of himself that he believes he can do every part of the gospel ministry himself. The gospel, if it is a full gospel, will include words, deeds, and prayer. Perhaps all people are called at least on some level to participate in all three of these aspects of the gospel, yet some will focus on words, perhaps others on prayer, and others on deeds of service and hospitality. Some will be called to act in these three capacities on behalf of the church in her formal and authoritative aspects (for instance the elders in their public ministry of shepherding). Others will be called to act as individual members of a church in informal and non-authoritative aspects (for instance the person that demonstrates to others Christ's practical mercy through hospitality in her home). But one thing is for sure: Paul said it well when he declared about the work of the church, “having then gifts differing according to the grace that is given to us, let us use them!”

In summary, another way to speak of a mission-driven church is to be that kind of church that seeks to bring a little bit of heaven to every nation. The church is that “little bit of heaven” as it represents the mediated presence of Christ to every nation while it awaits the full, consummate, and immediate presence of Christ in heaven. Please join your session in prayer, discussion, and action as we seek to see God's “heaven” brought to every nation of greater New Haven for the glory of Christ!



Preston Graham is the Pastor of Christ Presbyterian Church

Calendar of Events

September

- 1 Yale Fall term classes begin Teachers' meeting—6:30 pm
Servant Leaders' meeting, 7:30 pm
- 2 Community Lawn Concert, Tom Conlon
- 5 Congregational Meeting and Banquet
Promotion Sunday Activities Fair
- 8 Wednesday Fellowship Dinners begin—
6:00 pm
- 20 Cider Open House—7:00
- 25 Men's Prayer Breakfast
- 26 Welcome Dessert—7:00 pm



The men of the church at Men's Sports Day earlier this summer.



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